WRITING SAMPLE · PROGRAM EVALUATION

Natural Helper Program Assessment

A preliminary process evaluation of the Immigrant Welcome Center's peer-helper program: theory of change, evidence from comparable programs, stakeholder themes and recommendations.

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PROJECT NOTICE

This portfolio edition condenses the CRISP Research and Evaluation Clinic report Natural Helper Program Assessment (May 2021), co-authored by the author, and incorporates her logic model and project materials. Research support was provided by clinic staff.

Names of Natural Helpers and clients have been removed, and quotations are attributed only by role. Prepared for portfolio and professional evaluation purposes.

Executive summary

The Immigrant Welcome Center (IWC) asked the CRISP Research and Evaluation Clinic to identify what is working in its Natural Helpers program and where it can improve.

The clinic conducted a preliminary process evaluation: an assessment of how program activities take place, whether they are implemented as designed, and whether the program is accessible and acceptable to the people it serves. The team built a working theory of change, reviewed more than 20 studies and documents on comparable programs, analyzed a focus group with nine Natural Helpers and Specialists, interviewed a key IWC staff member, and reviewed program contracts and reports.

The evaluation found that IWC's greatest asset is its volunteer base. Unlike comparable programs that rely mostly on volunteers who have never immigrated, Natural Helpers come from the communities they serve and were often helping their neighbors long before joining IWC. Natural Helpers reported feeling more supported than ever during COVID-19, even as community needs rose sharply. The main opportunities for improvement involve the structure of participation, the volume and clarity of trainings, and the burden of data collection.

Key recommendations:

- Offer a menu of trainings that accommodates different skill levels, and clarify which sessions are required.
- Replace annual membership renewal with flexible levels of participation that let Natural Helpers step away and return.
- Restructure help forms into short status updates that capture feedback, training requests and support needs.
- Explore ways to increase language diversity among community partners, Natural Helpers and Specialists.

Background

The Immigrant Welcome Center

The Immigrant Welcome Center is an Indianapolis nonprofit whose mission is to be a trusted partner and advocate for all immigrants, guided by values of equity, accountability, collaboration and trust. It provides immigrant and refugee communities with peer-to-peer support, naturalization and legal assistance, and English language literacy through community partners and local leaders, and it helps organizations work more effectively with culturally and ethnically diverse populations.

IWC grew out of a 2005 study of immigrant newcomers' needs led by then First Lady of Indianapolis Amy Minick Peterson. Working with the Greater Indianapolis Progress Committee, she facilitated focus groups with service providers and studied best practices for immigrant and refugee assistance in other cities. By 2006, the Immigrant Welcome Center was established with the help of twelve initial Natural Helpers. IWC hired its first executive director a year

later, expanded in 2015, and at the time of this evaluation was preparing to move to a larger downtown office.

The Natural Helpers program

The Natural Helpers program is a grassroots volunteer program that provides direct help to immigrants and refugees settling in Indianapolis. Natural Helpers understand firsthand the challenges of moving to a new place, learning a new language, finding employment and establishing a home, and they connect newcomers with resources and opportunities in their own communities.

To join, volunteers meet with the IWC Program Coordinator and sign a New Natural Helper Contract. A former requirement that Natural Helpers speak more than one language is no longer enforced. The contract asks Natural Helpers to assist immigrants and refugees in their community, attend the new Natural Helper training and eight monthly trainings a year, complete the IWC help form for every client assisted, and communicate regularly with the Program Coordinator. A Natural Helper Code of Ethics sets out expectations for responsibility, respect, disclosure of conflicts of interest, and safety and legal concerns.

Natural Helper Specialists

In response to the disproportionate impact of COVID-19 on immigrant and refugee communities, IWC launched the Natural Helper Specialists program in 2020 to make pandemic outreach accessible and tailored to specific populations. By summer 2020, Specialists were assisting community members in 19 languages and collecting data to inform local policymakers.

Research questions

The evaluation was organized around three sets of questions:

- **Theory of change.** What is the theory of change for the Natural Helpers program?
- **Evidence from similar programs.** What are the key components of an effective helping program? How is community engagement maintained in similar programs, and how are organizational changes best implemented?
- **Strengths and gaps.** What are the current strengths and gaps in the curriculum? Is it culturally responsive? What types of training are effective for Natural Helpers, and are current training frequencies creating the desired impact?

Methodology

Data sources

- **Focus group** with nine active Natural Helpers and Specialists, exploring their experience during COVID-19, proposed levels of engagement, membership renewal, training preferences and recognition.
- **Key informant interview** with an IWC staff member responsible for the program.
- **Program documents**, including the New Natural Helper Contract, code of ethics, training manuals on culture and systems of care, the helping-process curriculum, help forms and

existing post-session training evaluations.

- **Literature review** of more than 20 studies and documents screened in Covidence, covering comparable volunteer programs for immigrants and considerations for serving immigrant communities.

My contributions

As one of four research assistants who co-authored the report, I:

- Built the program's logic model and theory of change with IWC staff.
- Contributed to the literature review on comparable peer-helper and community health worker programs, including the Promotores de Salud model.
- Developed a pretest/posttest assessment instrument to measure the effect of Natural Helper training.
- Participated in interviews with Natural Helpers and IWC leadership.
- Recommended revisions to the client help form Natural Helpers use to record their work.

Evidence from comparable programs

Program structure and development

Organizations serving immigrant communities recognize that newcomers need strong relationships in a new environment, along with an understanding of the barriers they face: limited language proficiency, little knowledge of local programs, discrimination, stigma and mistrust of authorities (Thomas et al., 2016). Programs like the Natural Helpers program address these barriers by equipping volunteers with knowledge of services and the skills to build trust.

Programs have struggled when immigrants are not part of the planning process. A Natural Helpers program in Dayton, Ohio had to rethink its strategy when it became clear that its planning committee did not represent or understand the experience of immigrants in the city. Organizers invited immigrants into a series of conversations built around the question "What is possible for you if you have the resources you need?" This revealed the limits of a "fix-it" approach that framed the program as a benefactor-beneficiary relationship and underemphasized mutual dialogue and cultural sharing (Lamping et al., 2018).

Other programs emphasize relationships from the start. The Hartford Public Library's Cultural Navigator Program in Connecticut was designed to facilitate integration through relationships between receiving-community members and newly arrived immigrants, treating social capital as a primary goal and casting volunteers less as service providers than as friends and conveners (Thomas et al., 2016).

Volunteer base

Several comparable programs rely mainly on volunteers who have never immigrated themselves. A cultural mentor program in a Rocky Mountain Front Range city recruited volunteer teams from churches and civic organizations; mentors were motivated by empathy and civic duty but had little understanding of the immigrant population (Brady, 2019). Hartford also recruited volunteers with limited experience and placed them in less specialized roles, such as staffing the library resource center or assisting with events (Thomas et al., 2016).

Lack of experience was a significant barrier for these programs. Volunteers felt unfamiliar with the bureaucratic systems immigrants must navigate (Lamping et al., 2018) and unsure how to approach unfamiliar cultural norms, including gender roles and family dynamics (Brady, 2019). Language was a major obstacle: mentors described working almost entirely with the family member who spoke the most English, and one team that was paired with a family where no one was comfortable in English reported that they were not able to help much (Brady, 2019).

Against this backdrop, IWC's volunteer base of people who have immigrated themselves is one of the program's greatest strengths. Natural Helpers can communicate more effectively and build trust more quickly, helping newcomers feel understood rather than isolated.

Training

Adaptability in training design emerged as a key theme. In Dayton, volunteers attend four five-hour trainings and receive a $200 stipend for attending three of the four. Initially, agency representatives presented dense information in lecture format, but volunteers valued dialogue and ownership over the program. The relationship formed with a representative during training proved more useful than information delivered by lecture, which required staff to prepare speakers to act as participants in an intercultural dialogue (Lamping et al., 2018).

Hartford's training focused on time spent with immigrants rather than specific services. Its materials told navigators that they did not need to be experts; they needed to know where to go in any situation and, when in doubt, to reach out to the program's intercultural liaison (Thomas et al., 2016).

Activities

Program activities are largely left to volunteers. Hartford encouraged navigators to run errands, attend events, share meals and be present in immigrants' lives, and its most important metric was the time navigators spent in the field (Thomas et al., 2016). By contrast, the Rocky Mountain program identified time as its biggest barrier: volunteers often could not commit enough time or underestimated the commitment involved (Brady, 2019). Mentors in that program described their role, in order of frequency, as socializing, responding to refugee-led emotional support and problem solving, offering advice or navigating systems such as financial literacy and credit, logistical support such as driving to appointments, teaching English, and teaching practical household skills (Brady, 2019).

Because Natural Helpers are already embedded in their communities, they can build on existing relationships in a way these programs cannot.

Findings

Theory of change

The team developed a working theory of change that traces the program from its inputs to its intended impact.

Inputs

- **Physical resources:** funding to compensate Natural Helpers for some activities (translation, speaking, mileage, gifts of appreciation) and to fund Specialist positions, plus public library space.
- **Knowledge resources:** service providers and partner organizations that conduct trainings.
- **Technology and communication:** WhatsApp, Zoom, Canva, text messages, a Facebook group and Facebook Live, email and loaned laptops.
- **Human resources:** about 30 new volunteers a year, volunteers who lead trainings, the Natural Helper coordinator, Natural Helper Specialists and an HR software platform.

Activities

- **Training:** monthly trainings, orientations, weekly calls, webinars, informal check-ins and extra trainings on request or in a crisis.
- **Collaboration and coordination:** creating promotional materials, helping partner organizations respond to immigrant communities, and Natural Helpers meeting with newcomers as needs arise.
- **Administration:** collecting and monitoring help-form data, tracking and reporting outputs, responding to Natural Helpers' requests, building weekly agendas and speaker schedules, checking in with active Natural Helpers and reconnecting with inactive ones, and designing trainings around Natural Helpers' needs.

Outputs

- Number of workshop attendees, trainings held and attendance at weekly calls and meetings.
- Orientation pretest and posttest results.
- Number of help forms submitted, activities Natural Helpers participate in and volunteer hours logged, recorded in a monitoring and evaluation logbook.

Outcomes

- **For IWC:** an active, engaged network of Natural Helpers; greater ownership of the program by Natural Helpers; greater representation of non-English speakers; and a stronger basis for advocating for funding and involvement.
- **For Natural Helpers:** stronger affiliation with IWC's mission; greater comfort, empowerment and self-advocacy in everyday life; stronger public speaking and facilitation skills; continued involvement on the IWC board and in other activities; greater knowledge of advocacy and systemic change; and professional development.
- **For the immigrant community:** greater autonomy, access to translation, knowledge of where to find trusted resources, and relationships with community organizations.

Impact

The program's long-term impact aligns with IWC's mission of connecting immigrants to community resources and helping them become more self-sufficient: immigrants and refugees gain access to positions of power in the city, an activated and representative group of advocates develops, newcomers can find the resources they need quickly and easily, and IWC can advocate effectively for immigrant needs in Indiana.

Key themes from Natural Helpers

Perception of purpose: Natural Helpers naturally help

> *"What's really special about the Natural Helper program is that everyone I know who has come through it is truly a natural helper." — Natural Helper*

Many Natural Helpers were already serving as advocates in their communities before partnering with IWC, which sustains the program's authentic, grassroots approach. Participants described helping as a lifelong identity rather than a role with an end date; several said that even when they stepped back from reporting, they never stopped helping.

Perception of purpose: clear boundaries matter

> *"I think the Immigrant Welcome Center should be able to … have a clear line between helping the clients and the Natural Helpers." — Natural Helper*

Need rose sharply during COVID-19. Natural Helpers described a shift from fear about immigration status to fear for community members' health and lives, along with rising requests for help with rent, utilities, health care and mental health. Because community members contact them based on personal trust, the line between their paid jobs and their volunteer role often blurred.

Affiliation with IWC: commitment levels differ

Natural Helpers were overwhelmingly positive about IWC; one long-serving participant described the past year as the easiest of their decade in the program because of the support, partner calls and resources IWC provided. Participants supported letting people choose how involved to be, including stepping away for a "sabbatical" and returning, but they objected to labeling less active members as "alumni" and strongly opposed annual membership renewal, which many felt would push people away. Several suggested a lighter check-in about every six months, with the door always open.

Impact of training: valued, but too frequent and unclear

Natural Helpers valued their trainings, especially legal and immigration sessions with attorneys, naturalization paperwork, domestic violence, technology and self-care, and they benefited from personal connections with partner organizations that let them bring resources back to clients. Their concern was volume and clarity: partner calls, webinars and trainings ran close together, and it was unclear which sessions were required. Most felt the eight required trainings in the contract were too many and suggested four to six a year, an annual orientation refresher, and the option to choose sessions relevant to their communities.

Technology and administration: data collection is difficult

Consistent data collection was the most persistent challenge. Natural Helpers wanted the help form to take only a couple of minutes, and some proposed a short periodic narrative of their work instead. They became more receptive once they understood that the data supports program staffing and funding. They also asked for clear, current guidance on fast-changing programs such as emergency rental assistance so they would not lose clients' trust, and for a directory of fellow Natural Helpers.

Assessment practices

IWC's existing training evaluations were post-session forms that asked participants to rate their agreement with topic statements (for a culture session, for example, "I can identify the ways culture shapes beliefs, practices and values"), rate the session's delivery and materials, and describe what they learned. These forms capture satisfaction and self-reported understanding but, without a baseline, cannot show whether a training changed what participants know.

The pretest/posttest instrument developed for this project addresses that gap by pairing matched items administered before and after each training across three domains: knowledge of key topics, beliefs and attitudes related to the content, and facilitation and delivery. Aligning these items with the logic model's Natural Helper outcomes lets IWC report change over time rather than satisfaction alone.

Recommendations

Natural Helpers program

- **Training menu.** Offer a variety of trainings that accommodate different skill levels and abilities, clearly label required versus optional sessions, and set a manageable number of required trainings each year, with an annual orientation refresher.
- **Flexible participation.** Define levels of involvement without the "alumni" label, allow Natural Helpers to pause and return, and replace annual renewal with a brief check-in about every six months.
- **Help forms as status updates.** Restructure help forms into short status updates sent before or after trainings, with space for feedback, requested trainings, assistance needed and what the Natural Helper believes is going well.
- **Clear guidance and connection.** Provide current guidelines on high-stakes resources such as rental assistance, and create an opt-in directory of Natural Helpers.
- **Matched measurement.** Use the pretest/posttest instrument for each training, aligned with logic model outcomes.

Future research

- Explore ways to increase language diversity among community partners, Natural Helpers and Specialists.
- Move from this preliminary process evaluation to an outcome evaluation once the new measures have been used for a full training cycle.

References

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